

REAL POLITICS

As regionalism powers Prashant Tamang to Indian Idol status, voting has emerged as the biggest winner in reality shows

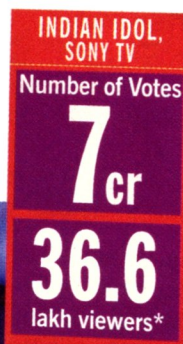
■ By Kaveree Bamzai

If the *Indian Idol 3* finals on Sony TV last week generated seven crore votes, the same week also saw 5.3 crore votes being cast for the ongoing Zee TV talent hunt, *SaReGaMaPa Challenge 2007*, as well as 10 lakh votes on Star's *Amul Voice of India*. Given that India has only 8.5 crore cable and satellite homes (which translates into 42.5 crore individuals) and that West Bengal, which is estimated to have cast 2.8 crore votes to power Prashant Tamang to victory,

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does not even figure on TAM's viewership measurement radar, this is particularly meaningful. Driving this frenzy is a cocktail of deep-seated regionalism and repetitive media exposure. So while there's no danger of reaching America's proportions—6.6 crore people voted in the *American Idol* finals this year, which is more than the 6.2 crore who voted for George W. Bush in the US presidential elections in 2004, compared to 36 crore people who voted in the general elections in India in 2004—entertainment has never been as political as it is now.

And it's not just the show-stopping special appearance on *SaReGaMaPa*, India's most-watched show in the past month, by Union Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav. Despite the East having the lowest mobile penetration in India (West Bengal has a tele-density of 10 per cent and Assam of 11 per cent compared to Delhi which has a tele-density of 94 per cent and Chennai 84 per cent), the people of Darjeeling pushed Tamang to the top using old fashioned PCO booths. There were reports that these were kept open all night-long to facilitate multiple voting—in contrast, in Shillong, Amit Paul's hometown, all the PCOs run by Nepalis remained shut the whole



UNLIKELY HERO: Tamang with actor John Abraham and first runner-up Paul (left to right)

* TAM figures for week ending September 15

